Corpus of Inscriptions in the Local Language(s) of Thrace

A preliminary overview

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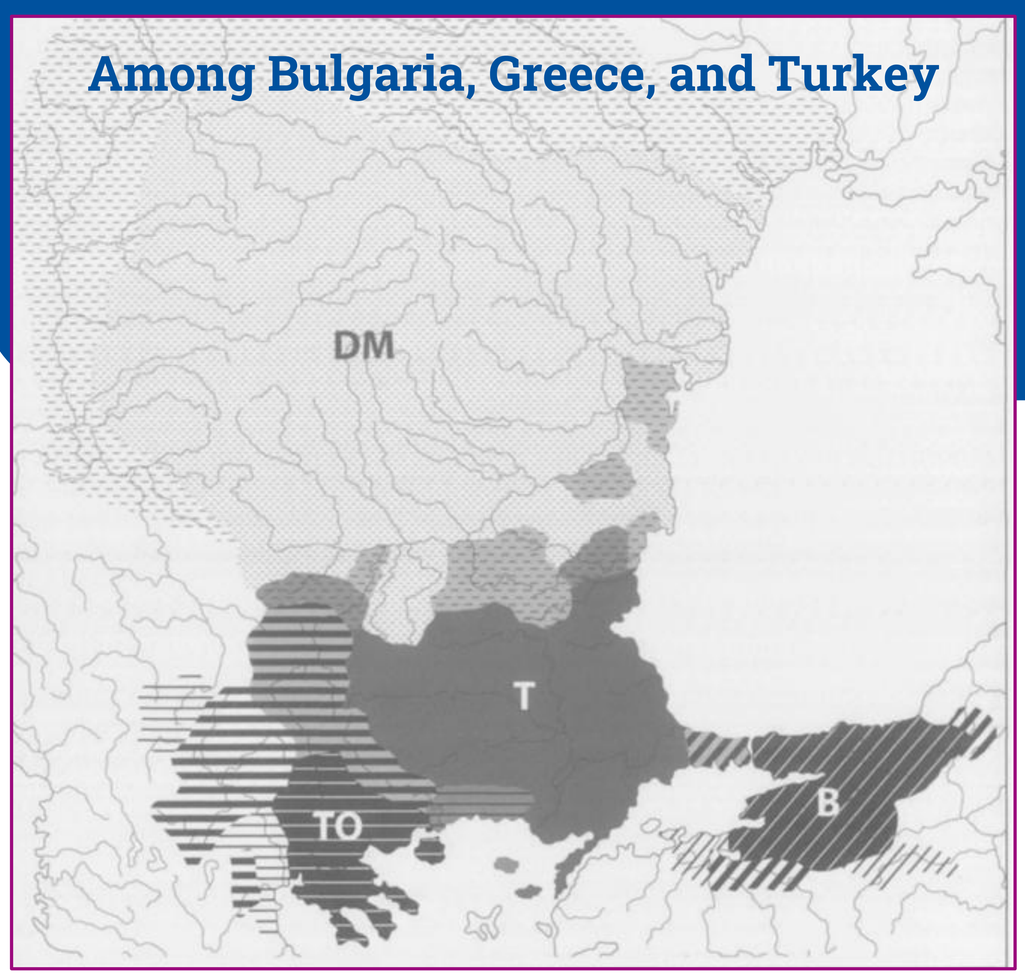
Winfried Kumpitsch, a colleague and friend, in memoriam

Thracian: what is it?

- ‘Thracian’ defines an extinct Indo-European language attested through onomastic data, glosses of Greek lexicographers, and a heterogeneous corpus of ca. 400 inscriptions.
- ‘Thracian’ inscriptions date between the 6th and the 4th century BCE and come from the Bulgarian and Greek Thrace.
- It cannot be ensured whether these inscriptions refer to the same language, more languages or (more probably) more variants of the same language.



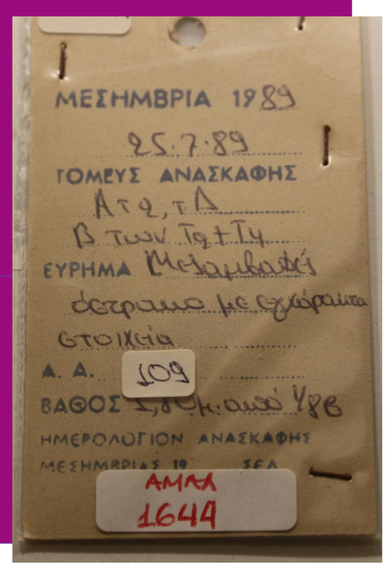
Two editions

- *Printed edition* with: (a) HQ photos of the documents; (b) comprehensive descriptions; (c) texts’ critical edition; (d) discussion of the contexts and the language, paleographic tables, and concordances.
- *Digital edition* with all the features of the print edition + some special inserts.

Comprehensive corpus of Thracian inscriptions

New photos and drawings

Microscope analyses of writing remains



Metadata and updated contextual information

Features and challenges of the digital edition

- Text of the inscriptions will be encoded in EpiDoc (and connected with images): EpiDoc standards are adequate to the Thracian material. Along with the edition, I will include the commentary (introductory), the apparatus (external approach), metadata, and the bibliography. Descriptions will adopt a FAIR vocabulary and comply with Bodard et al. (2021), “Modeling Epigraphy with an Ontology”, 10.5281/zenodo.4639508.
- Each recognizable word will be selectable and linked to a general database of words concordances.
- When the reading of signs is uncertain or non-existent in other epigraphic traditions, the transcription will report the signs as faithfully as possible, using the closest Unicode letter shape.
- Advanced textual search and browsing; exact criteria (location, chronology, personal names etc.) yet to be defined.
- Several statistical analyses on key-features of the inscriptions (provenance, context, typology, proximity to Greek material etc.)
- A constantly updated master bibliography of Thracian epigraphy.
- An interactive paleographic table and database, including statistical analyses, with signs’ variants tied to inscriptions and several metadata (e.g., provenance, material, purpose).

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